John Andrews details the concrete mechanical procedures of photography as a multi-step chemical and physical process, encompassing lens selection, glass plate preparation, exposure timing, developing baths, and chemical fixing (pg. 5–10). While critics view these chemical manipulations as purely mechanical routines, Andrews evaluates these technical realities as mere instruments to an end, he concludes that the true definition and purpose of art does not lie in the mechanical manipulation of silver salts or optical glass, but in using those technical tools to express human emotion, interpret natural beauty, and bring imaginative feeling in the viewer (pg. 8–11).

According to Andrews, a routine machine operator simply manipulates apparatus settings and exposes plates mechanically without aesthetic reflection (pg 12–15). Unlike a true artist, that possesses an internal visual consciousness and emotional sensibility. Making him able to unpack his assertion that one must learn to "wait and watch," we are told that this practice signifies deep artistic intentionality: the photographer must patiently observe changing atmospheric light, fleeting shadows, and natural compositions until the exact moment aligns with their inner creative vision (pg. 15–18). Simply pushing a shutter button is mechanical, but waiting for the ideal moment, that requires active artistic judgment.

We explore through Andrew's thoughts how he examines that photography serves traditional visual media like painting, drawing, and illustration (pg 19–28). He argues that photography should support the fine arts as an indispensable reference tool capturing fleeting anatomical movements, complex lighting ratios, and intricate landscape details for painters to study in the studio (pg 20–24). Rather than copying painting, photography liberates painters from tedious field recording, allowing them to focus on high-level

composition and expressive synthesis while operating alongside traditional media as a complementary creative discipline (pg 25–28)

Using Andrews's framework, the "artistic feeling" is the inner emotional, aesthetic, and imaginative consciousness of the creator. It embraces atmospheric sensitivity, visual intuition, and the subjective interpretation of light, balance, and mood prior to taking an image because with out artistic feeling, operating a camera is merely chemical and mechanical execution thatas why internal sensibility transforms this routine by guiding every technical choice framing, exposure, and timing making the camera an instrument of human intentionality rather than an automated recorder of optical data (Pg 8).

An alembic distills and cleans raw substances into a refined essence. Applied to art, raw nature works as an unrefined input, while human consciousness acts as the alchemy vessel. Art is not raw reality copied directly; it is raw reality distilled, filtered, and transformed through human thought and feeling (pg 12). The "alembic of man" subjects' external raw visual facts to intellectual selection, emotional filtering, creative arrangement, and aesthetic evaluation (Andrews, 1892, p. 12). It strips away chaotic or irrelevant details, infusing the scene with human meaning, subjective symbolism, and narrative focus.

We are shown that Hamerton believes the optical lens and chemical plate record visual phenomena automatically and indiscriminate of feeling (pg 12). Because the apparatus records physical reality directly without inherent human interpretation, he views it strictly as a mechanical documentation device, as such, a medium must allow the creator direct, unmediated expression of human imagination and emotional synthesis, where every line, tone, and mark originates from conscious artistic choice rather than automated physical

recording (pg 12). Hamerton argues that photographic technology ignores human distillation entirely, placing an optical mechanism between nature and the final image. Emerson's alembic framework, however, shows that an artist uses technical devices intentionally, passing visual choices through human consciousness before finalizing the work (pg 12).

Andrews presents photography and painting as sister arts operating within the same creative family, each utilizing distinct technical instruments to express subjective human feeling (pg 19–22). Positioning digital art within this lineage reveals it as a close cousin to traditional painting; digital painting tools still require direct manual stroke execution, color choices, and composition by human hands, albeit through digital tablets and pixels. Generative AI, however, occupies a primarly distinct technological category that unlike photography or digital painting, generative AI models synthesize imagery by evaluating statistical patterns across billions of dataset images in response to text prompts. Applying Hamerton's strict criteria, AI generation sits outside the fine arts because the machine performs the execution and visual synthesis autonomously (pg 12). Yet, using Emerson's "alembic of man" and Andrews's "artistic feeling," an argument emerges for its entry into the creative family: when a creator curates prompts, iterates across hundreds of algorithmic seeds, adjusts parameters, and digitally alters the output, the human mind remains the primary filter and guiding consciousness (pg 8- 12).

Strictly speaking, Jason M. Allen's entry of "*Théâtre D'opéra Spatial"* was not illegal or against the explicit rules of the 2022 Colorado State Fair's digital arts category. Because the competition guidelines did not explicitly ban generative software at the time, his submission violated no written regulations. Ethically, however, entering an AI-generated work into a division intended for human digital artists was wrong. It exploited a regulatory

loophole and undermined the unspoken premise of the contest: celebrating human technique, dedication, and skill. I agree with Hamerton's critique, prompt-based synthetic generation fundamentally fails to meet the standard of fine art because it eliminates the physical and technical craft central to artistic creation. Fine art requires time, delicate control, and years of dedicated practice to master a medium. Typing a text prompt to generate an image in seconds cannot replace the deep, hard-earned craft of visual art. When an algorithm handles the rendering, spatial perspective, lighting, and brushwork automatically, the process removes the direct physical labor and refined skill that give fine art its value.